



Discourse Studies in the Cultural Politics of Education

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Seven reasons to question the hegemony of Visible Learning

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ABSTRACT

The publication of John Hattie's *Visible Learning: A synthesis of over 800 meta-analyses relating to achievement* in 2009 has led to the widespread adoption of the Visible Learning program around the world. Critique of this program has been less widespread, especially in English, and has tended to centre on the mechanisms of meta-analysis. We consider what Visible Learning puts to work in relation to cultural politics and find it closely aligned with agendas of neoliberalism, sexism and ableism that operate to perform exclusion in schools and to de-professionalise teachers in feminised work. We argue that the metaphor of Visible Learning itself requires much more careful attention.

KEYWORDS

Visible Learning; inclusion; ableism; sexism; neoliberalism; John Hattie; metaphor

Introduction: the absence of critique

Visible Learning, as conceptualised by John Hattie (2009), has colonised the education landscapes of at least 23 countries (Knudsen, 2017). In Australia, this evidence-based package of effective learning strategies, based solely on meta-analyses of quantitative research, is endorsed by state departments of education (Department of Education and Training, 2017). As an international juggernaut, Visible Learning has made a celebrity of its founder and has been featured in an Australian television series, *Revolution School: Putting education to the test* (Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2017) as the potential saviour of public education and redeemer of recalcitrant teachers. Visible Learning is also currently expanding across the curriculum, into a series of books describing how each discipline can implement 'the practices that work best to accelerate student learning' (Fisher, Frey, & Hattie, 2016).

In this article, we explore our unease about the metaphor of Visible Learning and attempt to understand and unpack its hegemonic appeal. Critiques of Visible Learning seem nowhere near as prolific as how-to guides and tend to emphasise the mathematics, processes or validity of meta studies (Snook, O'Neill, Clark, O'Neill, & Openshaw, 2009; Terhart, 2011; Wecker, Vogel, & Hetmanek, 2016) rather than the philosophical or political underpinnings of the concept. Two recent articles, however, offer a more critical engagement, foregrounding concerns about, for example, 'performative effects of non-state policy actors like edu-businesses' (Knudsen, 2017, p. 253) such as Cognition Education, the company that has, until early 2018, disseminated Visible Learning's global teacher education programs. Scott Eacott (2017, p. 1) describes the uncritical worship of the scientific

cult of Visible Learning, with Hattie as guru, as ‘a tragedy for Australian school leadership’. We want to expand these critiques into an analysis of what the discourse of Visible Learning puts to work in relation to the cultural politics of teaching.

By invoking cultural politics, we recognise that people’s values, beliefs and opinions shape society and create the educational structures of governance that we work both within and against. A concept such as Visible Learning is therefore not neutral, but a contestable cultural site, imbued with relationships that work to augment power and control. We understand that there are different and competing versions of reality, and that our own cultural politics of inclusion informs how we engage in the field’s ‘struggles over *meaning*’ (Barrett, 1982, p. 37). We seek to foreground the workings of power in relation to Visible Learning as a global phenomenon formed of multiple actors and agencies. We do not seek to attack John Hattie, who has distanced himself from some of the ways his research has been taken up (Knudsen, 2017) as he continues his own evolving intellectual project. Our concern is with the ways Visible Learning has been discursively constructed and the politics of this work.

We are teacher-educators who experience demands to make learning visible in our tertiary classrooms. We both teach inclusive education, and our particular fields of interest are disability and gender studies. We are also experienced secondary teachers and we recognise much that is useful in Visible Learning’s strategies. Indeed, we have used some of the practices of Visible Learning for many years before they were co-opted by Hattie’s meta-analysis and re-packaged as Visible Learning, practices such as scaffolding learning and fostering metacognitive skills (Hattie, Masters, & Birch, 2016).

However, we also find Visible Learning troubling. In seductive neoliberal style, it promises ‘outcomes’ yet is couched in the language of more progressive educational philosophy – insisting, for example, that learning must be ‘shared with, committed to and understood by the learner’ (Hattie, 2009, p. 23) – making it difficult to resist. We offer here a distillation of our unease into seven points we hope will provide other educators with some purchase for their own critiques of Visible Learning, in the spirit of healthy debate and diverse opinion around any educational endeavour. We offer these ‘seven’ points provocatively and ironically, riffing on the management discourse that also pervades Visible Learning, the glib language of measurement, performativity and ‘delivery’ (Hattie, in Knudsen, 2017).

We apply our understandings about inclusive education to the overarching trope of Visible Learning; this is not a classroom study of the implementation of Visible Learning, but a theoretical engagement with its implications. Our emphasis is not statistics, but language, and we draw on a range of theoretical resources throughout, joining other critics of the dominance of the visual (Rorty, 1979) masculine orientations of visual culture (Berger, 1972; Mulvey, 1975), and the politically loaded nature of metaphor itself (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980; McKnight & Whitburn, 2017).

We argue that potent and colonising metaphors such as Visible Learning should be accompanied by an openness to critique and to negotiation, so that they do not become tools of a fascistic education (Pinar, 2011), or sticks with which to beat teachers. In the absence of a robust literature specifically critiquing the cultural politics of Visible Learning – as Hattie says, few have contested it (Hattie, Masters, & Birch, 2016) – for us to discuss and cite as a review, we move straight into our critique, and invite other

educators to engage with the following seven points of contention. We offer further explanation of our theoretical resources for analysis in these sections.

1. Visible learning carries political baggage

The choice of the term 'Visible Learning' is no coincidence in neoliberal contexts. Vision, as a dominant and colonising sense, is demonstrated by the God-like mastery of three-dimensional perspective by Renaissance artists, and recognised by critics of visuality (Berger, 1972; Mulvey, 1975). Visible Learning might be understood as one of the reinforcing phenomena of neoliberal othering (Springer, 2016). It implies that teachers and students are all powerful actors whose destinies are in their own hands, denying the multiple violences of state-mandated curricula, testing regimes, league tables and so on. Teachers are blamed in the media for not being visibly effective enough and surveillance over them is maintained, so that they are kept 'ontologically insecure' (Ball, 2003, p. 220) and therefore de-politicised.

Visible Learning is the perfect tool for the 'new management panopticism' (Ball, 2003, p. 219) that is not so new anymore; when learning must be visible, everyone can spy on everyone else. This surveillance culture is multi-layered: teacher over student, parent over teacher, principal over teacher, academic over teacher, state over teacher and state over academic. And of course, science over social science. Visible Learning requires a highly political positioning of viewer and learner, and the submission of the teacher to 'knowledge' created by the regime of the meta study, in a culture where teachers are defined by blame and deficit. In this culture, professionalism becomes the performance of compliance (McKnight, 2016).

Could the absence of critique around Visible Learning be the result of this culture, in which questioning this dominant discourse no longer suggests a teacher who is an intellectually and politically engaged activist (Sachs, 2003), but a shoddy, or lazy practitioner, someone operating 'in the dark'? Simon Springer's (2016) generative analysis of neoliberalism, while resisting treating it as monolithic, suggests several questions that we apply here to Visible Learning.

- What is congealing around Visible Learning? What does it reify, and to whose advantage?
- What are the violences of Visible Learning?
- Where are the flows of capital around Visible Learning? Where is capital accruing and what kinds of capital are accruing for those producing 'Visible Learning' as brand? What material and financial benefits flow on to teachers and students?
- What and where are local movements and resistances? We have already established that these do exist, in a muted way, but largely on social media. Anecdotally, we have found that both teachers and academics are hesitant to express doubts, and this is reinforced by other research (Knudsen, 2017); compliance is hegemonic and licences being recognised as a professional.

These questions do not have easy answers, but are intended to disrupt the conscription of educators into the ranks of the visible. It seems extraordinary, given the wide awareness of the ways the panopticon has been invoked in critiques of neoliberal education since the

early 2000s, that Visible Learning should be unreflexively welcomed in 2009 as appropriate for describing learning and empowering teachers. The *Big Brother* reality television show logo, and the Visible Learning logo are remarkably similar; excesses of visibility, of Michel Foucault's (1975/1995) dangerous exposure by light, are embodied in both.

2. Visible learning simulates pornography

As a tool of neoliberalism, Visible Learning might also be understood as a component of its sexist and masculinist 'thrust'. Presided over by a single, god-like male authority, the cult of Visible Learning is about blunt instruments, both at the level of the meta-analysis and what it demands in the classroom. Its fixation on 'ejaculatory outcomes', or rather, 'outcums' (McKnight, 2017) denies the critique of such neoliberal preoccupations (Connell, 2013; Eisner, 2017; Grumet, 1988). This theme is a central tension of curriculum studies, yet Visible Learning seems armoured against reasonable debate. Even John Hattie himself has attempted some degree of distance, by saying that if he had his time again, he would avoid the tyranny of outcomes (Knudsen, 2017).

Yet Visible Learning, as a phenomenon entangled with broader social and political forces, is no longer entirely under his control. Many of our university's pre-service teachers, indoctrinated in their placement schools, believe Visible Learning's dictates are the only way, and they must begin every lesson with a teacher-prepared list of finite and determinable outcomes on the board. Some schools now even have the learning outcomes mantra engraved or printed onto their whiteboards.

In Visible Learning's meta-analysis, the wisdom of teachers is taken, processed, and served back, at a price. Teachers, in a feminised profession (Apple, 1986/2013), submit to heteronormative, sexist and ableist constructions of education that operate discursively to structure what is valued and what matters in educational systems. And what matters is what is visible, with seeing and looking as historically the province of men (Berger, 1972), positioning women as the object of the male gaze and the source of male scopophilic pleasure (Mulvey, 1975). This preoccupation with the visual is enacted in education as a pornography of learning; this occurs through the intense production of visible proofs for a determining masculinised gaze and a fixation on what can be seen and known in a short time frame.

The word 'pornography' comes from the Greek *pornographos*, from the visual depiction of female slaves for the pleasure of others (Harper, 2018). Pornography has been described as 'an impetus towards the confession of previously invisible "truths"' (Williams, 1989, p. 7); this is an impetus that is ever increasing. As Andrea Dworkin (2003) says of the pornography industry, 'the numbers grow as the technology and its accessibility grow' (p. 388), encouraging 'more and more passive acquiescence to the graphic depictions' (p. 388). The 'graphic depictions', the money shots, in neoliberal education, are national testing results or league tables published online. In the classroom, they mean getting better marks, but not, for example, welcoming into a group a student who has previously been excluded (something that is not readily quantified and recorded).

To demonstrate this, we juxtapose questions about adolescent male viewing of pornography, from a teen self-help book, with modifications so that instead of addressing the boy looking at depictions of sex, we address the educator looking at data. Our purpose here is to emphasise the similarities between these orientations.

The teen book asks the boy:

How do you know if you have a problem with porn?

- 'You find yourself looking for more and more extreme kinds of porn.'
- 'Images that you used to think were shocking now seem ordinary.' (Frith & Brooks, 2013, p. 165)

We ask the educator:

How do you know if you have a problem with data?

- 'You find yourself looking for more and more extreme kinds of data.'
- 'Data that you used to think were shocking now seem ordinary.'

The cult of visibility is enacted in both cases. This drive to see has been described in relation to pornography as 'the frenzy of the visible' (Williams, 1989), recognised in the examples above not as desirable, but as pathological. It is no coincidence that Visible Learning (and teaching) must be 'explicit'. The Victorian Department of Education and Training's brochure (2017) compiling Visible Learning for teachers mentions the term 53 times. In relation to data, while teachers have always maintained student records, now they can collect data and surveil students to what would once have seemed an extraordinary and excessive extent, as well as being monitored themselves. University lecturers can check students' time online, and what they have accessed within a digital learning management system. These are examples of the conflation of data volume with insight (Kitchin, 2014) as addiction intensifies. The research project of Visible Learning continues; even 800 meta-analyses are not enough.

The following teen book advice for adolescent boys attempts to help them understand that the extreme, performative and highly visible demands of heterosexual pornography do not reflect what is valued in non-pornographic human sexual relationships (we note the conservatism and heterosexual bias of this source; however, it is relevant in considering gendered asymmetries of power in pornography and education):

- Most men and women DO NOT have incredibly large penises and breasts.
- Most people do not remove all their pubic hair.
- Most couples cuddle during sex, meaning they cannot see the penis going in and out of the vagina ...
- Most men ejaculate during penetration, and not onto their partner's face or body.
- Most men do not ejaculate lots and lots of semen (Frith & Brooks, 2013, p. 167).

We re-phrase this as advice to curriculum authorities enamoured of Visible Learning:

- Learning is not always visible or explicit.
- What matters is not only what can be seen and counted.
- Not everything needs to be marked or tested.
- The end outcome is not the point; volume does not equal quality.
- Science is not the only way of thinking about the world.
- Education is not delivery.

Visible Learning is predicated on a masculinist, positivist understanding that all teaching and learning can be quantified and known, and packaged up as inputs and outcomes. It assumes a scientific and behaviourist theory of learning, rather than understandings of teaching and learning as relational, contextual, messy, impossible to fully define or even necessarily articulate (Sellar, 2009); as such it may be recognised as part of a backlash (Faludi, 1992) against feminist and poststructuralist movements, and also, ironically, against student-centred learning tenets such as the negotiation of the curriculum (Boomer, 1992). There are other conceptualisations of teaching, for example as art, in which objectives are thought to be limited by their discursive nature (Stronach & MacLure, 1997) yet outcomes are taken for granted in Visible Learning.

There is much more to teaching than what can be reduced to discourse, and yet to venture into the realm of the emotional, or of affect, is to veer away from the certainties of masculinist science into a culturally ascribed 'feminine' that must be abjectified (Kristeva, 1982) as the inadmissible side of 'legitimate' teacher subjectivity. We note the racial implications, too, of glorifying what is light, bright and white, not concealed in the dark. Concepts such as love, honour, dignity and fear are also subjugated. Visible Learning enacts teaching as early twentieth century male factory work (Grumet, 1988), with this input having that output, and this action having this impact; 'impact' is yet another forceful, masculinist metaphor. Meanwhile, the labour being 'degraded and controlled' (Apple, 1986/2013, p. 25) is culturally inscribed as women's labour in a feminised profession.

3. Visible learning resists dialogue

The Visible Learning cult is not about teachers and students, but the Visible Learning brand. It is not dialogic, it brooks no argument and is sedimented and corralled by its trademarks and proprietary symbols. As we comply, we wonder if we should; assent and unease intertwined are the defining reactions to neoliberalism's imperatives. Educators need to be alert to affect here, and to what it may mean. Publically critiquing Visible Learning, Lucinda (first author) has experienced teachers in tears, distressed about what they are required to do to meet related targets in schools. What are the bulges of sensation here?

Teacher professionalism requires –

... working with colleagues in collaborative cultures of help and support as a way of using shared expertise to solve the on-going problems of professional practice, rather than engaging in joint work as a motivational device to implement the external mandates of others. (Hargreaves & Goodson, 1996, p. 20)

Visible Learning demands the latter, and not coincidentally, also requires the consumption of the artefacts, including the professional development sessions, the books, the websites and the videos. These almanacs, with their tips for teachers, offer quick fix solutions without addressing the crises of education in an increasingly complex world (Slee, 2011). In the case of the Visible Learning brand, certain teachers become licenced as fans, for example in collected case studies of impact (Hattie, Masters, & Birch, 2016). Visible Learning has effected the shift from intrinsic accountability to extrinsic accountability, negating teachers' awareness that 'professional knowledge is provisional, unfinalizable, culturally produced and historically situated' (Locke, 2015, p. 82). It cannot meaningfully be reduced to a list of strategies.

This shift has been achieved by taking teachers' knowledge, from the many studies that form the basis of their number crunching, and returning it to them as expert external advice. Visible Learning has entered classrooms as a version of multiplatform capitalism that positions teachers as compliant consumers of their own pedagogies. Visible Learning's teacher-customer, however, is constructed as deficient in knowledge, confined in autonomy to its iron-clad, research-proven data, and entirely responsible for student achievement, as if there are no other factors in play.

We note with concern, especially in relation to Pinar's (2011) fears re curricular freedom and the silencing of voices of dissent, what Hattie himself says (in an interview with Knudsen, 2017) about teacher training in Visible Learning:

We hire people to deliver it and only one in five passes. That is because almost every teacher wants to get up and talk about their story, their anecdotes and their classrooms. We will not allow that, because as soon as you allow that, you legitimise every teacher in the room talking about their war stories, their views, their kids. (Knudsen, 2017, p. 254)

Classic democratic professionalism (Locke, 2015; Sachs, 2003) is about expertise, autonomy and altruism. Visible Learning undermines these concepts. Under the surveillance of Visible Learning, teachers are not experts unless they subscribe to Visible Learning; they are no longer autonomous, but must comply rather than form their own judgments, and implementation is more important than concern. Visible Learning is about commands from on high, not the collegial dialogue that has underpinned these tenets of teacher professionalism for decades. Yet in classic neoliberal fashion, it sells teachers' knowledge back to them along with the illusion that this will make them ever *more* professional.

4. Visible learning neglects an ethics of care

Visible Learning pushes an ethics of care for community and others into a feminised and devalued status. Love, collegiality, generosity: it is difficult to measure and monetise these things, or create pan-global professional learning markets around them. Questions about teaching such as Noddings (1986) 'What effect will this have on the caring community we are trying to build?' (p. 499) are side-lined by Visible Learning, which defines teachers and students solely as individuals striving for standardised outcomes. Teacher knowledge is appropriated, congealed in books and professional learning programs, packaged and branded and then purchased by these same teachers to afford all the pleasures of hegemonic compliance. We 'see' traces of our ancient and deeply held educator wisdoms all shiny and new, in a list of 'what works', in effect radicalising us into the Visible Learning army. We sign up.

The accolades in the Visible Learning books and websites speak of classrooms transformed. Are these classrooms transformed because of Visible Learning itself, or those traces of which we are reminded? Are they transformed in the many different ways they might be if teachers were free to spend professional learning money as they like? Professional learning money always flows somewhere, to someone. Where is the accumulation of capital here?

Caring is inevitably about the local context, about knowing and responding to students (Connell, 2013). Visible Learning shifts the locus of knowledge from classrooms and schools, or even partnerships with schools, to universities and academics. Hattie does not foreground what he learnt from teachers with whom he worked, or ways in which

Visible Learning has been modified by teacher wisdom. This foregrounds again how proprietary this knowledge package is, how impervious to collaboration and teacher input; as Hattie says, 'it is scripted. To the word' (Knudsen, 2017). The most pervasive power is located with those who can conduct meta-analyses, and randomised controlled trials. This is the kind of knowledge that is valued, this is not teacher knowledge or student knowledge. Visible Learning, as a regime of control, is ultimately hostile and protectionist towards what falls outside its parameters. Fidelity, such an important concept to Noddings (1986), is not understood by Visible Learning as faithfulness to students, but as loyalty to an external concept. The local, social and contextual are de-valued.

5. Visible learning courts fascism

Should a single doctrine ever govern teachers, classrooms and schools? If we, the authors, were to develop a challenge to Visible Learning, should we be delighted to trademark it, copyright its materials and instigate a counter army of Not-so-Visible Learning acolytes? How often do professional learning programs on Visible Learning include critiques of Visible Learning? We have sought and found no evidence of reflexivity. How will schools that have invested heavily in Visible Learning, from plaques on the Visible Learning Coordinator's door, to Visible Learning dogma woven throughout courses and teacher practice, swing from one proprietary solution to another, as schools continue to react to the manufactured shocks (Springer, 2016) of neoliberalism?

Critiquing neoliberalism risks accusations of treating it as monolithic and we recognise that neoliberalism itself is always shifting, always assembling in new and yet familiar ways. Visible Learning is but one of its incarnations, in a complex educational environment of short-term teacher employment contracts, league tables, proposals for ever more benchmarking, high stakes testing, centralised curricula and the normalising of markets colonising state schools. Schools must do their own identity work in the marketplace by aligning with name brands such as Howard Gardiner, Edward de Bono and lately, John Hattie. Is it a coincidence that these recent educational gurus are all men? Eacott (2017) does not think so, associating Visible Learning with the 'great man' (p. 8) myth, of the male individual who can save education, and whose impact calcifies in educational systems.

Visible Learning is part of a totalitarian organised forgetting (Kundera, 1981) that conveniently fails to remember that its practices are teacher practices. It ignores Foucault's (1975/1995) warning that visibility is a trap, and of the dangers of 'the penetration of regulation into even the smallest details' (p. 200). Again, this masculinist and phallic metaphor of penetration describes the authoritarian nature of visual control. Pinar (2011) warns us that if teachers apply curriculum 'without understanding, there is only spectacle, fascism in our time' (p. 214). Visible Learning is spectacularly hegemonic in the Gramscian sense, in which teachers visibly accede to a regime of discipline through which they must insist on behaviours from students, and their schools must insist on behaviours from them. Only then is learning said to take place.

Teachers will pick and choose from the list of 'what works' that forms Visible Learning, even as their guts tell them externally mandated, evidence-based practices will not necessarily work for them (Biesta, 2007). Yet we cannot invoke Foucault without also acknowledging that there are multiple forms of resistance and varying degrees of complicity in hegemony. Our impression, though, based on feedback from hundreds of pre-service

teachers, in hundreds of Australian schools, is that Visible Learning carries with it an unprecedented imprimatur, stamped by the neoliberal insistence that a professional teacher is a compliant teacher. This has colonised teacher practice, and indeed, teachers' bodies to the extent that their physical movements in the classroom must conform: pre-service teachers must move to the board immediately on entering a room, to put up learning intentions. School management now forbids them to start lessons in any other way (McKnight, 2016).

Visible Learning as metaphor aims to colonise the performative pedagogical imagination (McKnight, 2016) so that teachers 'see' themselves teaching in particular ways and strive to make themselves ever more visible as Visible Learning teachers. This smacks of the individualistic, Sisyphean and depoliticising (McRobbie, 2005) work on the self to which Giddens (1991) aspired, distracting work that cannot be divorced from its political context. There is a long tradition of both women and teachers in a feminised profession, being incited to 'become producers of themselves as objects of the gaze' (Walkerdine & Ringrose, 2006, p. 37). Visible Learning makes students the object of this tyranny as well.

6. Visible learning oversimplifies

Visible Learning, despite all its complicated effect sizes, equations and figures, is ultimately too simple a mantra. To assume that teachers can see what students see is both ableist and sexist (predicated on masculinist vision), and also arrogant. To reduce teaching to what works is to misunderstand it. To define growth only as getting 'to the next level' (Hattie, in Waack, 2018) is to narrow the potential meanings of success. Yet Visible Learning is based on research for the times of Brexit and Donald Trump, when populism, ableism, jingoism and chauvinism seem to be on the rise. These movements are characterised by aggressive and hostile policy towards what is considered to be foreign, or other (on Trump's fear of what will not conform, read Harnish, 2017).

In the case of Visible Learning, this means teacher knowledge that is not filtered and authorised by statistical analysis. In a feminised profession, this is feminine knowledge. 'Impact', that preoccupation of both Visible Learning and neoliberal policy, means 'a forceful contact' (Merriam-Webster, 2018). Both the Cambridge and Oxford dictionaries illustrate 'impact' with examples of bullets and artillery shells. The metaphor of 'impact' belongs to a crude and behaviourist theory of education as transmission, and forceful transmission at that. 'Know thy impact' (Hattie, Masters, & Birch, 2016, p. 3), Visible Learning's mantra, with its biblical tone, is reactionary, coming after poststructural and postmodern questioning of knowledge. Again, this is no coincidence, but a shoring up of certainties when they have been on the brink of melting away.

The eye, limited to that single function of sight, hides its inadequacies behind arrogance, and insists that seeing is the only way. As Hattie writes, on the eye's disciplinary role in the production of the self:

Teachers must see learning through the eyes of students, seeing teaching as the key to their ongoing learning. The remarkable feature of the evidence is that the biggest effects on student learning occur when teachers become learners of their own teaching, and when students become their own teachers. When students become their own teachers they exhibit the self-regulatory attributes that seem most desirable for learners (self-monitoring, self-evaluation, self-assessment, self-teaching). Thus, it is visible teaching and learning by teachers and students that makes the difference. (Hattie, 2009, p. 271)

Yet, as with most bullies, the eye is a vulnerable organ, with the whole bony orbital structure being designed to protect the flimsy lens and precarious function of sight. The eye needs to be belligerent, as it is essentially made of vitreous jelly. The statistics of Visible Learning's all seeing, all knowing eye are similarly vulnerable. The discipline of positivist, scientific research is just another fiction, one research narrative amongst many.

7. Visible learning is founded on ableist assumptions

The concept of Visible Learning, with its insistence that only the visible matters, makes a normative and ableist assumption about the faculties people should have in order to be counted as successful and included. The act of naming the visible as the principle means and proof of knowledge creation perpetuates long-held biases against diverse ontologies. Without consideration of these assumptions, schools practising Visible Learning risk narrowing understandings of ability and working against the inclusion of diverse teachers and learners.

Ableism 'posits two distinct and entirely clear ontological zones: disabled and abled' (Campbell, 2009, p. 8); in Visible Learning, the capacity to perceive through sight is the normalised zone, while to perceive by other means is to be obliterated, both ontologically and epistemologically. The teacher or student with a visual impairment is constructed through the lack of sight, and inevitably excluded. This kind of 'impact' on equity, engineered by educational discourse, is not included in Visible Learning's effect sizes. Though Hattie himself contends that Visible Learning is underpinned by a continual process of meta-analysis to identify potential falsifiability (Knudsen, 2017), our contention is that 'impact' needs to be considered in terms of inclusiveness. This reveals how the philosophical underpinnings of Visible Learning foreclose particular ways of being and knowing.

Vision has long carried a brute reputation as the defining and ruling faculty of awareness; the history of critique of the arrogant assumptions of vision goes back to Richard Rorty's *Philosophy and the mirror of nature* (1979). Sight has also been critiqued as representative of a symbolic order used to secure ideological and normalised dominance (Michalko, 2001). We urge others to question 'compulsory ableness and its conviction to and seduction of sameness as the basis to equality' (Campbell, 2009, p. 4). Inclusive education theory has demonstrated how exclusion is couched as collective indifference to diverse learners (Slee, 2011), an indifference central to the language of Visible Learning.

Conclusion: initiating dialogue

These challenges to the hegemony of Visible Learning are intended to initiate dialogue and to support diverse critique, before even more is invested into making Visible Learning an unsailable component of school programs. In speaking to teachers, we have found that many have concerns similar to ours, but that they are silenced by senior staff in their schools, who have hitched their own branding to particular bandwagons. There are dangers to educational freedoms and to teacher professionalism when schools have paid for pedagogy.

We argue that learning is not always visible, not always quantifiable, that it can be elusive, messy, unpredictable and not always desired. It cannot be purchased, but occurs relationally, rather than through the implementation of externally conceived interventions. Every time educators invoke 'Visible Learning', they negate those who draw on multiple sensorial resources for knowledge creation. Visible Learning complies with

masculinist regimes and contributes to an authoritarian, colonising 'vision' of education that is part of broader neoliberal education policy and governmentality. This is not to take away from Hattie's scholarship as a statistician, or from the useful reminders it may offer teachers. Instead we seek to caution that the discourse of Visible Learning diverts questions of equality in education. We critique the hegemony and dominance of Visible Learning, and the way it positions teachers and learners.

Yet are we similarly guilty, of positioning teachers as in deficit, unaware of being taken over, and ventriloquised by academics? We have acknowledged teacher resistance and the competing calls to professionalism teachers face. How easy is it for teachers to share their doubts about Visible Learning? The hegemony of Visible Learning may be realised in schools through the absence of the following kinds of discourse:

- We resist corporate branding in our school.
- We value teachers' professional knowledge above anything.
- We have a critical approach to educational research.
- We use Visible Learning selectively and strategically; our teachers are engaging in the ongoing and dialogic process of determining 'what works' for them and their students.
- Context is more important for us than compliance.
- We consider our understandings of learning to be much more sophisticated than those of Visible Learning.

We hope our thoughts here may energise dialogue around Visible Learning and teacher professionalism and encourage others to enter the fray. We are also fundamentally suspicious of the ways ableism and sexism operate with corporatist and consumerist ideologies (Lazar, 2007) to create needs and direct flows of capital. Others may consider this in relation to Visible Learning, and reach their own conclusions. There are many reasons why our critique may be conveniently dismissed or side-lined, without full engagement with our ideas. We welcome robust debate that does not shirk interrogating the cultural politics of discourse. There will no doubt be more than seven reasons to question the hegemony of Visible Learning, and we hope others will lengthen our list.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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